Week 15: The Gospel

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

The Gospels tell one story four different ways — tonight we'll look at what each author is doing with it.

1. What's a piece of genuinely good news you've received in your life that changed how you saw everything else going on around you at the time?

2. **Read John 20:31.** According to this verse, why does John say he wrote these things down? What does it mean to you that the Gospel writers weren't just trying to record history, but were trying to persuade you to actually trust and follow Jesus?

3. **Read Luke 2:1-21.** Who is the news of Jesus' birth announced to first, and how does the angel describe it? Why do you think this news is first delivered to shepherds rather than to religious or political leaders?

4. **Read Luke 4:16-21.** In his hometown synagogue, Jesus reads a passage from Isaiah and then says, "Today this Scripture is fulfilled in your hearing." What does the Isaiah passage say he's been sent to do — and who is it for? What does that tell you about what the "kingdom of God" actually looks like when it shows up?

5. **Read Mark 15:21-47.** Who's present at the cross in this passage, and what does the centurion say when Jesus dies? Mark spends a huge portion of his short Gospel on the last week of Jesus' life, and this passage is a big part of why. Why do you think the Gospel writers treat the crucifixion, of all things, as the climax of the entire story?

6. **Read Mark 16:1-8.** What do the women find when they arrive at the tomb, and how does the text say they respond? Why might Mark choose to end his Gospel on a note of alarm, trembling, and silence instead of a more confident, victorious one?

7. Skim the opening of each Gospel — **Matthew 1:1-17, Mark 1:1-8, Luke 1:1-4, John 1:1-14.** Four writers, one subject, four completely different starting points: a genealogy, a wilderness preacher, a formal preface, the beginning of everything.

What does each author's choice of *where to begin* tell you about what he most wants you to see in Jesus?

8. The Gospel writers rarely tell you outright how to feel about Jesus — instead they show you how other people in the story respond to him and let you make up your own mind. Where have you seen your own response to Jesus mirrored in one of the characters we read about this week?

9. As you think about the whole message of the gospel — that God's kingdom has broken into the world through Jesus — what's one part of your own life where you need to let that news actually change something this week?